

DESIGNER

COMME DES GARÇONS

Spanning four decades, the label Comme des Garçons is unique, set apart from any other within the fashion industry. Created by Japanese designer Rei Kawakubo, the company was established in 1973 and has been attracting interest and controversy ever since.

Kawakubo began her career in advertising in the 1960s, and was a self-taught designer. After launching Comme des Garçons, she opened her first boutique, solely for women, in 1975. The late 1970s and early 1980s saw an expansion into menswear; in 1978 a men's line, Comme des Garçons Homme, was added to the label.

The "poverty" look

After moving to Paris in 1980, Kawakubo showed her designs there the following year, to howls of outrage. All the ideals of Western womanhood in the 1970s and 80s – beauty, charm, sex appeal – were missing. Instead, the press reported loudly on the "post-Hiroshima" look of poverty and destruction. The clothes were deliberately tattered and torn, and the collection featured a great deal of black – shape and construction being more important than colour. Comme des Garçons (meaning "like the boys") was the opposite of what women were meant to look like.

Kawakubo criticized the very concept of fashion. Her clothes were more like sculpture than couture. She challenged the prevailing silhouette, cleverly using fabric to create a different aesthetic of revealing and concealing. Her second collection, shown in Paris for Spring/Summer 1983, featured drab colours in rough fabrics and garments full of holes. It promoted a new "beggar" look of beauty in destitution, again challenging Western concepts of glamour.

Awards and criticism

Despite initial criticism, by the mid-1980s Comme des Garçons was well on the way to international fame. In 1985 Kawakubo held her first show in the US, and the following year she won a Fashion Group International Award. Comme des Garçons' branding became synonymous with art-house magazines and cutting-edge photography that almost pushed the clothes into the background, adding to their air of mystery.

For Spring 1992, Kawakubo showed garments that looked like the paper patterns of clothes rather than the clothes themselves. In 1995 she roused fierce criticism from Jewish groups for showing male models with close-cropped hair wearing striped pyjamas; and for Spring 1997, she sent outfits with bulbous padding down the Paris catwalk, genuinely shocking an audience that thought it had seen it all before.

More surprises

Kawakubo favoured surprising venues and unexpected collaborations. In 2004, for example, she began to roll out a series of "guerrilla" pop-up shops in locations away from traditional fashion capitals. These outlets, which included one in an old bookshop in Berlin, were run on small budgets and were intended to be short-lived. Comme des Garçons also collaborated with the huge high-street retailer H&M on a ready-to-wear collection, which was released in the Autumn of 2008 to great critical and consumer acclaim.

Kawakubo continues to confound her critics (and also her admirers), for instance, designing a dress for the fashion doll Barbie, which formed part of Comme des Garçons' *Jingle Flowers* collection.



△ PRIVATE ICON

Although often at the centre of controversy, Rei Kawakubo has always preferred to stay out of the limelight and is rarely photographed or interviewed. Her trademark look, seen here, comprises a basic black uniform and hair styled in a severe, blunt bob.

◁ ALL-WHITE

Kawakubo's Spring/Summer 2012 collection featured full-skirted white dresses worn with short boots.



TIMELINE

1967 After early career in advertising, Kawakubo starts work as a freelance designer

1942 Rei Kawakubo born in Tokyo

1973 Comme des Garçons established as a company

1981 First collection shown in Paris

◁ 1984 Spring/Summer collection features Comme des Garçons' signature deconstructed look

1986 Kawakubo wins Fashion Group International Award

▷ 1997 Spring/Summer collection continues to challenge conventional fashionability with padded clothing

2004 First of "guerrilla" pop-up shops opens in Berlin

2008 Launch of collection in collaboration with high-street retailer H&M

○ 1940

○ 1960

○ 1970

○ 1980

○ 1990

○ 2000



◁ **BOLD AND BRIGHT** This vibrant coat appeared in Comme des Garçons' Autumn 2012 show. Such outsize, "cut-out" shapes and solid colours were prominent in the collection.